When Should Institutions Change How They Forecast?

AI has likely reached parity with elite human forecasters on ForecastBench. The decision that matters is what evidence would justify changing an institution's forecasting process, and that standard should be fixed before the next striking result arrives.

For decision-makers in government agencies, central banks, public-health bodies, and AI companies · Megi Zimmermann · August 2026

About this brief. Independent policy brief by Megi Zimmermann, August 2026; not commissioned, published or adopted by any organization. The 26 October revision corrects quotations and attributions, narrows claims to what the sources support, adds sources that predate the August dateline and adds the postscript below; its recommendation is unchanged.

In July 2026, the Forecasting Research Institute (FRI) reported that leading AI systems had likely reached parity with elite human forecasters on ForecastBench. Their performance was statistically indistinguishable from the frozen 2024 superforecaster benchmark rather than clearly superior. FRI's Longitudinal Expert AI Panel (LEAP) sets a higher bar: a system exceeding a threshold derived from that benchmark, which the median panelist places in 2028 among superforecasters, 2030 among experts, and 2033 among the public. For institutions that rely on forecasts, the consequential question is not whether AI has reached parity, but when the evidence is strong enough to change how they forecast.

Suppose you are responsible for forecasting geopolitical crises, disease outbreaks, or the economic effects of advanced AI.[1] A forecasting model begins performing about as well as the world's best human forecasters on a rigorous benchmark. Do you incorporate it into your process? Give it equal weight? Or wait for stronger evidence? Those questions stopped being hypothetical this summer.

Answering them requires distinguishing two thresholds. One is a performance threshold: whether AI forecasts are statistically comparable to those of elite human forecasters. The other is a decision threshold: whether the evidence is strong enough to justify changing how an institution forecasts. ForecastBench speaks to both, but not in the same way.

Developed by FRI, a nonprofit focused on high-stakes forecasting, ForecastBench compares AI systems with human forecasters on unresolved real-world questions. Because both predict before outcomes are known, it evaluates forecasting rather than recall.[2] Its questions are of two kinds: market questions, drawn from prediction platforms such as Kalshi, Metaculus and Polymarket, and dataset questions, generated automatically from real-world time series. It maintains three leaderboards, and the July parity result refers specifically to the tournament board, which is open to external teams using tools and ensembles.[3] To make results easier to interpret, FRI converts the conventional Brier score into a 0–100 Brier Index: 100 is a perfect forecast, 50 is chance-level, and higher is better.[4]

Approaching Parity Is Not the Same as Crossing the Threshold

Frontier systems have closed the gap quickly. In the ForecastBench paper, on a 200-question set, superforecasters recorded a Brier score of 0.096 against the best language model's 0.122, where lower is better.

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[1]Throughout, "institutions" means organizations that routinely rely on forecasts to allocate attention or resources, among them government agencies, central banks, public-health bodies, and AI companies.

[2]Ezra Karger, Houtan Bastani, Chen Yueh-Han, et al., "ForecastBench: A Dynamic Benchmark of AI Forecasting Capabilities," ICLR 2025, arXiv:2409.19839.

[3]ForecastBench live leaderboards, forecastbench.org. The baseline board is run solely by the ForecastBench team; the preliminary board includes resolved dataset questions; the tournament board permits external submissions, tools, and ensembling. Checked 13 August 2026.

[4]Simas Kučinskas, Houtan Bastani, and Matt Reynolds, "Making Forecasting Scores Easier to Interpret: Introducing the Brier Index," FRI, 4 March 2026. Checked 13 August 2026.

On the Brier Index introduced in March 2026, where higher is better, the leading systems scored 67.9 against the superforecasters' 70.6. In July, FRI reported that several tournament submissions were statistically indistinguishable from the human benchmark, with one-sided bootstrap p-values ranging from 0.14 to 0.41. Cassi AI also became the first named system to rank above the superforecaster median forecast on market questions.[5]

That milestone is narrower than it sounds, and the narrowness matters. The superforecaster entry Cassi passed is a plain median of the forecasts of about eight superforecasters per question, gathered in a nine-day exercise in 2024 that included a group forecasting stage, under what Good Judgment calls "severe time constraints."[6] In the forecasting tournament where superforecasters were identified, putting both psychology and statistics to work produced the best forecasts two years in a row; the methods included elite teams of superforecasters and statistical pooling that weighted forecasts by past accuracy and recalibrated them. Pooled that way, forecasts from teams of tournament participants beat a prediction market that a simple average of poll forecasts had lost to.[7] No published ForecastBench comparison yet sets a model against that format.

The strongest current evidence is also not a direct, contemporaneous human-AI comparison. The human forecasts were collected in 2024, while current systems answer different questions, so ForecastBench adjusts statistically for question difficulty. FRI cautions that this comparison becomes less reliable over time. The planned fall 2026 superforecaster round therefore matters not simply as another leaderboard update, but as a test of whether parity survives against a current human baseline.[8]

Good Judgment, which grew out of the research that identified superforecasters, raises several objections in an April post. The first is the one above in stronger form: the comparison is extrapolated rather than head-to-head, because superforecasters answered a fixed set in a single 2024 engagement while AI is scored on entirely different questions. The second is that the questions which have resolved so far skew toward short horizons and dataset types offering "abundant historical data, clear base rates, and short feedback loops," which is where language models should be expected to do well.[9]

Another bears on the benchmark's central design claim. ForecastBench scores forecasts made before outcomes are known, but Good Judgment notes that its dataset questions "are no longer novel": their "nature and resolution sources are now fully disclosed to model developers," who have every incentive to "teach to the test." In its words, "What was a blind challenge for the Superforecasters in 2024 is now an open-book exercise

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[5]Brier scores from Karger et al. (cited above), arXiv v5 of 28 February 2025, Table 2 (superforecasters 0.096 against the best model 0.122 on the 200-question subset; raw Brier, lower is better). Brier Index values from Kučinskas, Bastani, and Reynolds, 4 March 2026 (70.6 against 67.9; higher is better). Parity finding, one-sided bootstrap p-values (Cassi AI 0.41; xAI 0.16 and 0.15; Google DeepMind 0.14), and the market-question milestone from FRI, "AI models have likely reached parity with superforecasters on ForecastBench," 16 July 2026. Checked 13 August 2026.

[6]Good Judgment, "What ForecastBench Doesn't Measure (Yet)," 14 April 2026: "Participants were presented with a large volume of questions under severe time constraints." On the benchmark's human entry, Karger et al. (cited above), §4.2: "a minimum of 3 forecasts were recorded for each question, with an average of 8 responses per question"; the 39 superforecasters forecast over a nine-day exercise that included a group forecasting stage (§4.2); and §4: "We scored each group's median forecast, treating it as representative of its overall performance." Checked 26 October 2026.

[7]Barbara A. Mellers et al., "Psychological Strategies for Winning a Geopolitical Forecasting Tournament," Psychological Science 25, no. 5 (2014): 1106 to 1115: "Putting both statistics and psychology to work produced the best forecasts 2 years in a row"; Barbara A. Mellers et al., "Identifying and Cultivating Superforecasters as a Method of Improving Probabilistic Predictions," Perspectives on Psychological Science 10, no. 3 (2015): 267 to 281, on "assigning them into elite teams of superforecasters"; Pavel Atanasov et al., "Distilling the Wisdom of Crowds: Prediction Markets vs. Prediction Polls," Management Science 63, no. 3 (2017): 691 to 706: "prices from the prediction market were more accurate than the simple mean of forecasts from prediction polls," but "team prediction polls outperformed prediction markets when forecasts were statistically aggregated using temporal decay, differential weighting based on past performance, and recalibration." Abstracts read 26 October 2026.

[8]FRI, 16 July 2026, "Next steps": a fresh superforecaster round, updated dataset questions, and quantile questions, all slated for fall 2026.

[9]Good Judgment, "What ForecastBench Doesn't Measure (Yet)," first of its methodological points, and its section on what is actually being scored. Checked 13 August 2026.

for AI teams in 2026."[10] The design does rule out contamination in the strict sense, since no answer exists when a forecast is made. Two weaker routes stay open. Paleka and colleagues found in 2025 that questions from non-market sources follow only a few basic templates.[11] As rounds resolve, a team can tune to them. On market questions, a system can borrow the crowd's answer: given market prices in its prompt, GPT-4.5 copied them, its forecasts correlating 0.994 with the prices provided, a tactic FRI says "reveals little about underlying capabilities."[12]

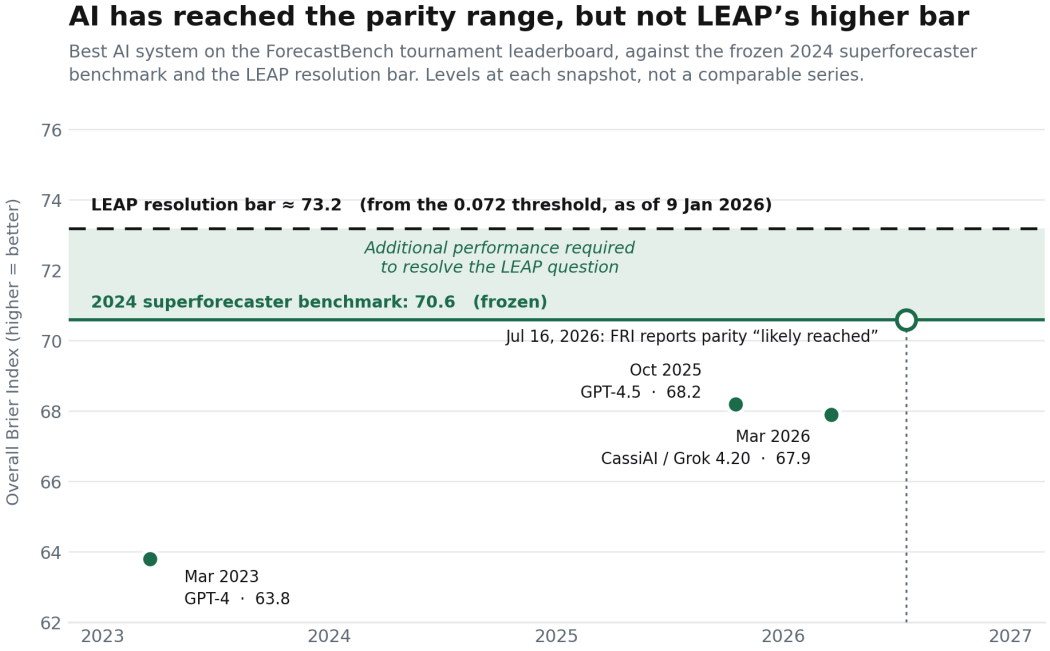
The same July report contains a result that cuts the other way. FRI's preliminary leaderboard, which surfaces submissions once at least 225 dataset questions have resolved rather than waiting for tournament-board qualification, had three Torchcast submissions at the top, and FRI states it expects many of these systems to rank higher than superforecasters on dataset questions once they reach the tournament board.[13] On that reading the tournament board lags the frontier rather than defining it.

[10]Good Judgment, same source, second of its methodological points: "The dataset questions are no longer novel." "Their nature and resolution sources are now fully disclosed to model developers," who have every incentive to "teach to the test." Checked 26 October 2026.

[11]Karger et al. (cited above), abstract: "To avoid any possibility of data leakage, ForecastBench is comprised solely of questions about future events that have no known answer at the time of submission." Daniel Paleka, Shashwat Goel, Jonas Geiping and Florian Tramèr, "Pitfalls in Evaluating Language Model Forecasters," arXiv:2506.00723 (2025): questions from non-market sources "follow only a few basic templates" (§3.3), and "ForecastBench does show fewer obvious temporal and logical leakage issues compared to other attempts" (§5). Checked 26 October 2026.

[12]Forecasting Research Institute, "How well can large language models predict the future?," 8 October 2025: "When provided market forecasts in their prompts, multiple LLMs," GPT-4.5 among them, "simply copy them"; "GPT-4.5's predictions have a correlation of 0.994 with provided market forecasts"; "Since prediction markets are highly accurate, this tactic works but reveals little about underlying capabilities." Checked 26 October 2026.

[13]FRI, 16 July 2026, preliminary leaderboard: submissions appear once at least 225 dataset questions have resolved, and FRI states it expects many of these systems to rank higher than superforecasters on dataset questions once they appear on the tournament leaderboard. Checked 13 August 2026.



Points are shown unconnected on purpose. The open marker on the benchmark line is the July report: reported, not scored, because statistical indistinguishability is not a point estimate (one-sided bootstrap p = 0.14–0.41). Brier Index = (1 − √difficulty-adjusted Brier) × 100, so 0.072 converts to 73.17, shown as 73.2. Difficulty adjustments are recomputed as questions resolve, so the three snapshots are levels rather than a comparable series; the Mar 2023 point is least comparable, and is placed at model release rather than at a leaderboard snapshot. FRI did not publish exact July leaderboard values.
Sources: FRI ForecastBench posts (8 Oct 2025; 4 Mar 2026; 16 Jul 2026);
LEAP Wave 5 report (23 Feb 2026). All checked 13 Aug 2026.

Figure 1. Leading systems have reached the parity range but not LEAP’s higher resolution bar. The July 16 report appears as an open marker on the benchmark line rather than a plotted score, because statistical indistinguishability is not a point estimate.

What LEAP Is Actually Forecasting

But parity is not the outcome LEAP is forecasting. The corresponding LEAP question asks when an AI system will surpass the elite human benchmark, not when it will become indistinguishable from it. It resolves only once a system achieves a difficulty-adjusted Brier score below the lower bound of the 95% confidence interval of the 2024 baseline: 0.072 as of January 9, 2026.[14] Setting the threshold before the result is known is what makes it a good forecasting question. Parity does not establish that a system has consistently exceeded the existing standard, nor that organizations should redesign high-stakes processes around it. The evidence required to recognize technical progress is not the evidence required to change institutional practice.

LEAP makes the distinction tangible. Asked when a system would clear the higher threshold, superforecasters gave a median forecast of 2028, experts 2030, and the public 2033. The reversal is striking: the same class of forecasters whose 2024 performance defines the benchmark expects it to be surpassed soonest.

[14]LEAP Wave 5 (“Security and Geopolitics”), surveyed 12 January to 2 February 2026 and published 23 February 2026. N = 229 experts, 54 superforecasters, 703 public. Resolution threshold: a difficulty-adjusted Brier below 0.072, the lower bound of the 2024 superforecaster median’s 95% CI, as of 9 January 2026.

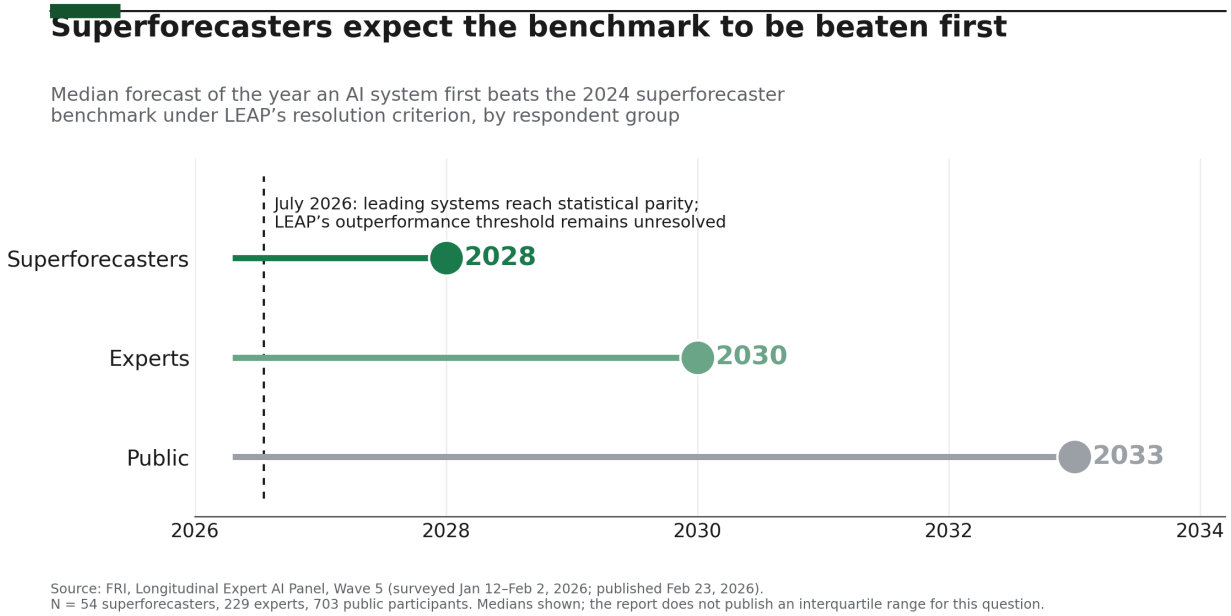


Figure 2. LEAP panelists' median forecast for the year an AI system first beats the 2024 benchmark. Superforecasters, the group defining the benchmark, expect it to fall first.

These forecasts sit against FRI's own extrapolation, which in January 2026 projected overall parity around November 2026, and disaggregated that into June 2026 for dataset questions and August 2026 for market questions.[15] By July, leading systems had already become indistinguishable from the benchmark, yet respondents had placed the higher outperformance threshold years away.

The rationales complicate the picture. The superforecasters' earlier median does not necessarily imply greater confidence in AI forecasting ability. Several respondents argued that the benchmark's design makes an early crossing likely for reasons partly unrelated to forecasting judgment, pointing to the frozen 2024 baseline and repeated model submissions, and LEAP's analysis names superforecasters in particular among those who stressed that "the way ForecastBench is structured advantages LLMs in a way that makes it more likely that one will hit the target score." One respondent who expected an early crossing put the arithmetic plainly: "Given enough evaluations, eventually one will fall under this mark by chance… [Indeed, if] multiple models are tested every 2 weeks, the chance of this happening becomes quite high, so this question is really testing when models reach near parity, rather than any improvements over superforecasters."[16] That is a property of the design once systems come close to the bar, not only an opinion about it. The threshold was set in advance, the submission process is open, and attempts accumulate across rounds with no stated cap, so the probability that some submission crosses by chance rises with the number of submissions. It also explains how the tournament board can lag the frontier and overstate it at the same time: qualification delays new entrants, including the preliminary-board leaders FRI named in July, while selecting the best of many entries tends to overstate the winner. Their

[15]FRI, "LLMs Are Closing the Gap on Human Superforecasters," 29 January 2026: overall parity projected around November 2026 (95% CI: January 2026 to November 2027), with dataset-question parity estimated for June 2026 and market-question parity for August 2026. Checked 13 August 2026.

[16]FRI, LEAP Wave 5, ForecastBench Performance question, rationale analysis, 23 February 2026. LEAP credits the design argument to "high-forecast respondents" and "in particular, superforecasters," and the "by chance" rationale to an early-resolution respondent. Teams may submit up to three forecast sets per round, and rounds fall every two weeks (ForecastBench, "How to submit to ForecastBench," and changelog entry of 19 November 2025); no cap across rounds is stated. On selecting the best of many entries, Paleka et al. (cited above), §3.2, describe a winner's curse: when many models with different biases are benchmarked, the top performer's score is likely to be overstated. Checked 26 October 2026.

reasoning distinguishes between beating the benchmark and demonstrating genuine forecasting superiority, which are not the same thing.

The impatient reading deserves stating at full strength. FRI projected overall parity for November 2026 and dataset-question parity as early as June. Parity arrived roughly on schedule. Invoking a second, higher threshold once the first has been met looks less like rigor than like a target that moves. And an institution that waits for a live comparison group will spend a year declining a capability its peers are already using, at a cost no leaderboard reports.

LEAP set the higher threshold in January, six months before parity arrived. The reply to the rest is not that this reading is wrong about the trend. It is that the rationales quoted above are the reason to keep the two thresholds apart, and LEAP credits the design argument above all to the panel with the earliest median rather than the most cautious one. A threshold that can be crossed by accumulating attempts is a fact about the benchmark, not about the forecaster, and LEAP names superforecasters, the class whose 2024 performance defines that benchmark, among those who stressed that its structure makes a crossing more likely.

From Performance Thresholds to Decision Thresholds

ForecastBench tells us when frontier systems begin matching elite forecasters under controlled conditions. Institutional adoption asks something else: whether that performance can be trusted in the environments organizations actually face, a gap no leaderboard can close on its own. The relevant question is not simply whether AI has reached human-level performance, but what evidence would justify giving its forecasts greater influence over real decisions, and that threshold should be specified before the next striking leaderboard result arrives.

What Evidence Should Change Institutional Practice?

Current evidence is strong enough to justify testing frontier AI systems inside institutional forecasting workflows, but not strong enough to treat them as generally superior to elite human forecasters. The sensible response is neither immediate delegation nor passive waiting, but staged adoption tied to evidence specified in advance.

Institutions should begin with shadow deployment. AI systems can produce forecasts alongside existing analysts without changing the weight placed on human judgments, and their performance should be evaluated not only in aggregate but by domain, forecast horizon, question type, and information environment. An intelligence agency should not infer from strong performance on structured economic indicators that the same system will handle a novel political crisis.

The next step is conditional integration. AI forecasts should receive formal weight only where systems show sustained performance over multiple rounds and against a current human comparison group. A single leaderboard snapshot is too sensitive to which questions resolved, which systems entered, and how difficulty was estimated, which is exactly why the fall 2026 superforecaster round matters more than another comparison against the frozen benchmark.

Only after those results generalize should institutions consider workflow reallocation: letting AI forecasts lead where performance is repeatedly validated, while retaining independent human forecasting for novel, sparse-data, or fast-moving situations. Human input should not shrink to reviewing a machine-generated answer after the model has already framed the problem. In higher-uncertainty settings, analysts should form an initial

forecast before seeing the model's output[17]; otherwise apparent human-AI collaboration becomes little more than human ratification of the model's judgment, and the institution loses both a genuine comparison and the capacity to catch what the system has missed.

Before changing forecast weights, institutions should pre-register at least five evidentiary conditions.

1. Test against a live human baseline, not only the frozen 2024 benchmark.
2. Require outperformance sustained across multiple rounds rather than appearing in one volatile snapshot.
3. Disaggregate results across market and dataset questions, domains, and horizons, because aggregate parity can conceal where humans and machines retain distinct advantages.
4. Test whether human-AI combinations, formed by pooling forecasts made independently, outperform either working alone.
5. Scale the standard to reversibility. Where a wrong forecast produces a cheap and reversible error, shadow deployment can be compressed. Where the error is irreversible, require outperformance against a live baseline before any weight is assigned.

The appropriate threshold varies with the cost of error, and the asymmetry is worth making concrete. An agency that gives AI forecasts formal weight a year early risks allocating scarce attention against a miscalibrated signal in precisely the novel, sparse-data situations the benchmark says least about. An agency that waits two years spends them running a slower process while a cheaper one performs comparably on the structured questions that make up much of its routine load. Neither error is free, and they are not the same size in every institution.

This recommendation has a condition under which it should be withdrawn. If the fall 2026 round shows outperformance against a current human baseline, sustained across more than one scoring round and holding when results are disaggregated by question type, then staged adoption is too slow and conditional integration is already justified. If parity does not survive a live comparison group, the staged approach holds. Either way the standard belongs on the record now, before the result is known, for the same reason FRI set its own threshold in January.

Conclusion

The LEAP medians suggest the higher threshold could be crossed within a few years, but institutions will face decisions about AI forecasting long before the question formally resolves. The fall 2026 superforecaster round will be the first real checkpoint, not because one new comparison should trigger adoption, but because it will test whether parity survives against a current rather than frozen human baseline. The institutions best positioned for that moment will not be those that have already delegated forecasting to AI, nor those that have refused to experiment. They will be those that have run systems in parallel, measured where they add value, and decided in advance what evidence would justify giving them greater weight. ForecastBench is valuable not because it tells institutions when AI has won, but because it turns a subjective question into an empirical one: rather than

[17]In Philipp Schoenegger et al., "Wisdom of the Silicon Crowd: LLM Ensemble Prediction Capabilities Rival Human Crowd Accuracy," Science Advances 10, no. 45 (2024), GPT-4 and Claude 2 improved after seeing the median human forecast, but "simply averaging human and machine forecasts yields more accurate results." In Danny Halawi, Fred Zhang, Chen Yueh-Han and Jacob Steinhardt, "Approaching Human-Level Forecasting with Language Models," NeurIPS 2024, averaging the system's and the crowd's forecasts gave the best score across 914 test questions: "in every setting the aggregate (average) of our system and crowd prediction is the best." Checked 26 October 2026.

debating whether AI should influence high-stakes decisions, institutions can specify beforehand what evidence would justify changing how they forecast, and then test whether that standard has been met.

Postscript, 26 October 2026. Since this was written, ForecastBench has announced a superforecaster-LLM tournament for 25 October, the fall superforecaster round discussed above; results are pending. On FRI's tournament leaderboard, a Google DeepMind entry now ranks first with a Brier Index of 69.1 against the superforecaster median's 68.8 (higher is better), with overlapping confidence intervals. No system has reached LEAP's threshold, a Brier score of 0.072 as of January 9, 2026, or about 73 on the Index; the best stands at 0.095 (lower is better). On Metaculus, the community forecast for when large language models will exceed superforecasters on ForecastBench stands at June 2027. In Metaculus's spring 2026 tournament, an aggregate of the ten best bots trailed an aggregate of ten Pro forecasters by a margin too small to be statistically significant.[18]

[18]forecastbench.org, featured post "Superforecaster-LLM tournament on Oct 25," dated 25 October 2026. FRI tournament leaderboard (dataset repository forecastingresearch/forecastbench-datasets, leaderboard_tournament.csv), read 26 October 2026: Google DeepMind "fire hedgehog" 69.1 (95% CI 67.9 to 70.5); superforecaster median forecast 68.8 (67.2 to 70.5); lowest overall Brier score 0.095. Metaculus question 40290, "When will large language models exceed superforecasters' accuracy in ForecastBench?," current estimate 16 June 2027 (12 forecasters), read 26 October 2026. Metaculus, "Spring FutureEval Results: Pros Beat Bots, but the Gap is Nearly Gone," 2 September 2026: bot team score –1.25 (95% CI –4.87 to 2.37), one-sided p = 0.247; a team of the top ten bots against a team of ten Pro forecasters, 99 questions. Conversion by FRI's formula, Brier Index = 100 × (1 – the square root of the Brier score): 0.072 is about 73.2.